



GUIDE

Manager's Guide to Tough Conversations

Difficult conversations are part of leading people. This simple framework helps your managers handle feedback, conflict and performance chats with confidence and fairness.

Before the conversation

- Be clear on the single outcome you want.
- Stick to specific facts and examples, not labels.
- Choose a private setting and enough time.
- Assume good intent — go in curious, not accusing.

A simple structure (the 4 A's)

- **Ask** — open with a question and listen first.
- **Acknowledge** — reflect what you heard.
- **Align** — agree on the issue and the goal.
- **Act** — set clear next steps and a follow-up date.

Phrases that help

- “I’ve noticed... and I wanted to understand what’s going on.”
- “Help me see it from your side.”
- “Here’s the impact it’s having...”
- “What support would help you get there?”

After the conversation

- Summarise agreements in writing.
- Follow up when you said you would.
- Recognise improvement early and specifically.

Ready-to-use scripts

Adapt these openers to your own words and situation.

1. Underperformance

"I want us to succeed, so I need to be straight with you. The last three reports came in late and that held up the team. Help me understand what's getting in the way — and let's agree how to fix it together."

2. Repeated lateness

"I've noticed you've come in late most days this week. I'm not here to judge — I want to understand if something's going on and how we make the start time work."

3. Attitude / tone with the team

"In yesterday's meeting, the way that came across landed badly with a couple of people. That's not the impact I think you intended — can we talk about it?"

4. Conflict between two staff

"I want to hear both sides separately, then together. My goal isn't to assign blame — it's to get us back to working well. Walk me through what happened from your view."

5. Declining a request (e.g. raise/promotion)

"I really value what you bring. Right now I can't approve this, and I want to be honest about why — and exactly what would need to be true for it to happen."

6. Letting someone go

"This is a difficult conversation. We've decided to end your employment, effective [date]. I'll walk you through the details and the support available. I want to handle this with respect."

Follow-up note template

"Hi [name], thanks for talking today. To recap what we agreed: [points]. Next steps: [actions, owners, dates]. I'll check in on [date]. I'm here if you need anything before then."